

Donations don't build nest egg, so Raptor Center adds visitor fees

By **PAT BORDEN GUBBINS**

Staff Writer

When the Carolina Raptor Center dedicated its new building May 24, the staff depended on the visiting public's generosity to donate sufficient operating money.

For the first six weeks or so, the public was welcome at no charge. Visitors were, however, asked to make a donation at the door.

Those donations, as it turned out, averaged 34 cents per person. And that was not nearly enough to keep the Raptor Center going, says Director Pat Marcum.

So, on July 1, the Raptor Center began charging entrance fees.

► "It costs about \$400 a day to operate the Raptor Center, and we're not a county agency," Marcum said. "We don't get county operating funds or public tax funds, so we have to find a way of operating on our own."

In addition, she said, the Raptor Center applied for three grants and was turned down in each case — including the \$50,587 asked of the Arts & Science Council.

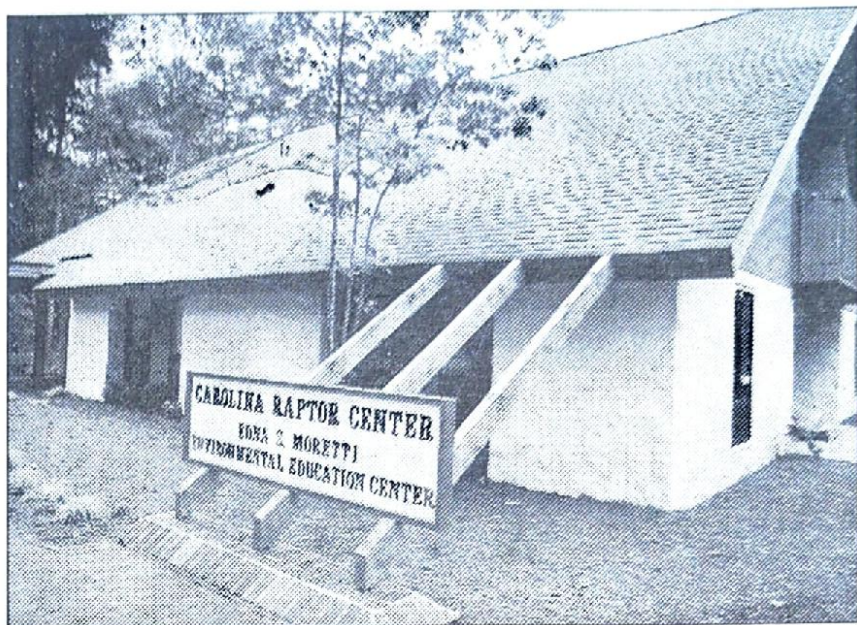
"We were one of the new agencies that applied to the Arts & Science Council this year and were turned down because of their tight funds," Marcum said. "Environmental causes have not reached the top of the priority list yet."

The Raptor Center has a history of scraping by on next to nothing, going back to the days when students cared for orphaned and injured birds of prey in the basement of the science building at UNC Charlotte.

For 10 years, volunteers worked out of two mobile units on a 57-acre site at Latta Plantation Park, in northwest Mecklenburg County.

The new center at the same site was built with the help of a \$100,000 donation from Fred Moretti, a Charlotte contractor, and his wife, Edna. The Raptor Center's board raised another \$180,000 for the building.

Things are going well, other than having to impose admission fees, Marcum said. "We are enjoying the new building and building



T. ORTEGA GAINES/Staff

New building: Contractor Fred Moretti and his wife, Edna, gave \$100,000 toward the Raptor Center's new building.



Pat Marcum

some new cages. We just completed one for northern harriers and are getting ready to build one for Cooper's hawks."

Eventually, at least 10 cages will be constructed along the extended nature trail that winds for about a quarter of a mile behind the big "condo cage" where the raptors are kept.

"The possibility is we'll open up seven days a week," Marcum said. "But now, we need at least one day a week to do maintenance."

Starting in September, Education Director Deborah Sue Griffin plans to offer special programs in the amphitheater.

In September, she plans to offer a program on bird migrations, followed in October by a program on flight. "It's not confirmed, but possibly in November, we'll have something about American Indian mythology relating to raptors," she said.

"Our goal is to create interest for visitors who come frequently, so they'll want to come back and hear something different."

If you're going

The Carolina Raptor Center at 6000 Sample Rd. in Latta Plantation Park is open 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. Tuesday through Sunday. Admission is \$2 for adults, \$1 for those 60 and older and for students; children younger than 6 are admitted free when accompanied by a parent. Members admitted free. Family memberships are \$30. Group rates of \$1 each are available with advance notice. Details: 875-6521, 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. weekdays.